

CASE ID: 201902710920

EPISODE NAME: China–New Zealand Huawei 5G Dispute

2019/02/12 - 2019/03/29

Sender: China (710)

Target: New Zealand (920)

Issue: Retaliation (16)

Final Outcome: Stalemate after Sanctions Imposition (9)

Summary:

On 2019/02/12, China postponed the launch event for the 2019 China-New Zealand Year of Tourism, as well as New Zealand Prime Minister Jacinda Ardern's trip to Beijing, in response to New Zealand's ban of Huawei's 5G technology on 2018/11/28. The launch event was rescheduled to 2019/03/29, though Huawei remained banned from New Zealand's 5G network.

Narrative:

On 2019/02/12, China postponed the launch event for the 2019 China-New Zealand Year of Tourism, a campaign to increase international tourism to New Zealand from mainland China, which was set to occur the next week.¹ On the same day, an Air New Zealand international flight from Auckland to Shanghai turned around and returned to New Zealand, citing administrative reasons.² Furthermore, New Zealand Prime Minister Jacinda Ardern's trip to Beijing, previously scheduled for November 2019, was postponed.³ These sanctions by China were in response to New Zealand's earlier actions concerning Chinese tech company Huawei's 5G technology.

On 2018/11/28, New Zealand banned Huawei from the country's 5G network, following similar decisions by fellow members of the Five Eyes Anglophone intelligence alliance.⁴ The Director-General of New Zealand's Government Communications Security Bureau reasoned that

¹ "Signs of strain? China postpones New Zealand tourism campaign," *South China Morning Post*, February 12, 2019, <https://www.scmp.com/news/china/diplomacy/article/2185819/china-postpones-new-zealand-tourism-campaign-amid-concerns>.

² Roy, Eleanor. "Huawei tells New Zealand: Banning us is like banning the All Blacks," *The Guardian*, February 12th, 2019, <https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2019/feb/13/huawei-tells-new-zealand-banning-us-is-like-banning-the-all-blacks>.

³ Ibid.

⁴ Meagan, T. "New Zealand bans Huawei from 5G, China has message for New Zealand," *South China Morning Post*, March 6, 2019, <https://www.scmp.com/week-asia/geopolitics/article/2186402/new-zealand-bans-huawei-china-has-message-new-zealand>.

using Huawei technology would pose a significant risk to national security.⁵ On 2019/02/12, Huawei presented high-profile ads in New Zealand's two largest newspapers saying that, "5G without Huawei is like rugby without New Zealand," and that without Huawei, New Zealanders would miss out on better and cheaper 5G technology.⁶ That same day, the deputy managing director of Huawei New Zealand, Andrew Bowater, expressed frustration over the Huawei ban, stating, "There has been no evidence of wrongdoing by Huawei presented, and we strongly reject the notion that our business threatens New Zealand in any way."⁷

The China-New Zealand Year of Tourism event was rescheduled to 2019/03/29.⁸ Relations between New Zealand and China remained chilled in the following years, although China was still New Zealand's largest trading partner in 2024. Data from China's Ministry of Commerce showed a value of \$22.86 billion USD in trade between the two countries, with exports to China making up 20.6 percent of New Zealand's total goods exports.⁹ Huawei is still banned from New Zealand's 5G network.

⁵ "New Zealand govt rejects telco's plan to use Huawei 5G equipment." *Reuters*, November 27th, 2018. <https://www.reuters.com/article/business/media-telecom/new-zealand-govt-rejects-telcos-plan-to-use-huawei-5g-equipment-idUSL4N1Y31L1>.

⁶ Graham-McLay, Charlotte. "New Zealand Fears Fraying Ties With China, Its Biggest Customer." *The New York Times*, February 14th, 2019. <https://www.nytimes.com/2019/02/14/world/asia/new-zealand-china-huawei-tensions.html>.

⁷ Roy, Eleanor. "Huawei tells New Zealand: Banning us is like banning the All Blacks," *The Guardian*, February 12th, 2019, <https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2019/feb/13/huawei-tells-new-zealand-banning-us-is-like-banning-the-all-blacks>.

⁸ "China-New Zealand Year of Tourism event back on." *Radio New Zealand*, 11 March 2019. <https://www.rnz.co.nz/news/political/384472/china-new-zealand-year-of-tourism-event-back-on>

⁹ Shijia, Ouyang. "New Zealand firms double down in China as bilateral trade ties deepen." *China International Import Expo*, June 30th, 2025. <https://www.cjie.org/zbh/en/news/exhibition/news/20250630/49390.html#:~:text=Since%20the%20signing%20of%20the,which%20averaged%207.7%20percent%20annually>.